coalition is facing a bad dilemma: the PM told his acolytes that Defense Minister Gallant would resign if no acceptable compromise was found, given the situation in the army. Avi Maoz announced that he would not vote automatically with the coalition, but would decide his vote case by case. A number of Likud Knesset members denounced Rotman's compromise as surrender. It's hard to see how Netanyahu will get out of this without a real compromise, at least along the lines of Herzog's proposal.

In a speech to former members of Betar (the youth movement of Begin's Irgun) in Paris, Smotrich, on a private visit, reportedly declared: There is no Palestinian people. The Palestinians are an invention of less than a hundred years. My grandparents were the true Palestinians, etc. Unfortunately, as will be remembered, this was an opinion also shared by Israeli socialists like Golda Meir.

Betar was already strong in Paris in the immediate post–World War II years. After the socialist Habonim ("the builders") refused to send me to Eretz Israel, during the prestate months of early 1948, because I was too young to fight, I changed the date of birth on my ID and, on the advice of a friend, presented myself at the headquarters of Betar, Hotel des Deux Mondes, Avenue de l'Opéra. They quizzed me: "What do we want?" My friend had prepared me and I shot back: "Both banks of the Jordan!"—exactly Smotrich's map of greater Israel that stood next to the podium during his speech, and which incensed the Jordanians. In 1948, I had but a very fuzzy idea of what both banks of the Jordan meant.

The Paris Betar leaders were hotheads then and later, and when Menachem Begin, the commander of the Irgun, indicated his readiness to cancel the sailing of the *Altalena*—by then docked in Port-de-Bouc, with 900 passengers aboard and tons of weapons —because of Ben-Gurion's warning to desist, the heads of the Paris Betar, in mid-June 1948, gave the ship the order to sail.